

Dirty habits

Good hygiene usually helps animals to stay healthy, but for some, habits that seem dirty to us can actually help in the fight for survival. Many mammals wallow in mud or leave messages by spreading their urine. Sloths hide in the treetops by letting algae grow in their fur.



Grubby coat

Unlike most mammals, the sloth does not groom its fur. Microscopic algae grow on the hairs, giving its coat a greenish tinge and a moldy smell.



Sticky messages

Bushbabies, or galagos, live and feed in trees. They wash their hands and feet with urine either to mark their territories or to improve their grip.



Mud bath

The warthog does not have sweat glands, so it cools down by wallowing in mud. Mud also helps to protect it from bloodsucking flies.



You scratch my back...

For chimps, grooming is an important social activity involving all the members of a troop. Chimps groom each other to maintain bonds and to defuse tension after a dispute. In a troop, the smartest, strongest, or most forceful chimps earn a high rank, or importance, in chimp society. Low-ranking chimps groom others the most, while dominant ones spend a lot of time being groomed, but often do not groom the others.

Preen clean

Feathers need constant care, and birds can spend hours a day maintaining them by preening. This Japanese crane uses its beak like a precision instrument, nibbling its feathers so that they lie flat. At the same time, it removes lice and other parasites and covers the feathers with a waxy substance from its preen gland. Many birds wash in water before they preen, but some ground-dwelling kinds—including chickens and grouse—keep their feathers dry and bathe in dust instead.



Young feather louse



Crane's bill probes beneath its feathers to get oil from the preen gland—a swelling at the base of its tail

Ticklish moment

Like a feathered mountaineer, a yellow-billed oxpecker clings to the neck of a giraffe. This African bird spends most of its life aboard large mammals, where it hunts for ticks and other parasites using a beak that is flat like a pair of shears. Oxpeckers help their hosts by getting rid of pests, but they also peck at wounds, which makes it harder for them to heal.

Earwax can provide extra food for oxpeckers



Oxpecker braces itself with its tail